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TECH SPEAK

Cyber-hit?: You say you've never 'net surfed and wouldn't know a web page from a hole in the wall? Heart race at the thought of sitting in front of a video game system that's not even for sale in this country yet?

Get thee to Cybersmith.

Based on a preview tour of the store, which officially opened in Cambridge today, the latest X-smith in the Booksmith-Videosmith-Learningsmith empire looks like a winner for "newbies" and "technoheads" alike.

Boston boasts a handful of cafes with one or two computer terminals for patrons' use, but nothing we've seen comes close to this.

It's a heck of an idea: Take 48 computer terminals, set them up with the latest CD-ROMs, games, connections to the Internet and commercial on-line services, and specialty applications such as make-your-own morph or screen saver. Add virtual reality "pods," an upscale coffee bar and munchies that can be ordered by patrons on-line, and a crew of "Technosmiths" to guide novices. Oh, and sell the latest computer books, magazines, and CD-ROMs, too. Voila, Cybersmith.

According to Jed Smith, Cybersmith's vice president of technology and son of X-smith empire founder Marshall Smith, techno-whizes from MIT's media lab had a hand in creating the snazzy screens and applications that appear on Cybersmith's system.

While slipping a membership card into a slot to play may remind you of pumping quarters into a pinball machine, this is no video arcade experience.

Cybersmith, located at 36 Church St., Cambridge, is open Mon.-Sat. 9 a.m.-11 p.m., and Sun., noon-10 p.m.

Black History CD: A new interactive CD-ROM based on the book "African Americans in Boston: More Than 350 Years," is coming to schools, community centers and businesses across the city on Wednesday.

Produced by Ken Granderson, of Inner City Software in Dorchester, the CD-ROM includes searchable pictures and text from the book published by the Boston Public Library in 1992. Granderson says he's produced two versions of the program, one for personal computers, and one for display on touch screens in public kiosks.

In addition to being shown in schools, the multimedia presentation will be on display in public locations such as Shawmut Bank's Washington Park branch in Roxbury, and the Mo Vaughn Youth Development Program in Dorchester.

Net show: It won't all be LANs and client-server talk at the Networks Expo at the Hynes Convention Center next week. The trade show's attendees are being invited to surf the 'net at an "Internet Theater." The theater will contain 40 workstations, and classes on the hour will cover standards such as FTP, Telnet, Mosaic and Newsgroups. The show runs Feb. 14-16.

Have a heart: If you're looking for a goody for your Valentine online, check out http:www.amdahl.com/internet/events/Valentine-1995.html, for one-stop shopping. Example: A pointer to the "Cyrano Valentine Server" which will compose a customized e-mail to your sweetie.

MICHELLE JOHNSON

▶ *Readers may send comments, questions and calendar items to Plugged In by e-mail (plugged@globe.com) or "snail mail" (Plugged In, Boston Globe, Boston, Mass. 02107-2378). Please state whether your letter and e-mail address are for publication.*

A dream of children becoming 'infonauts'

■ **PLUGGED IN**

Continued from page 69

er it might lead and however long it might take.

Hinting of contests and scholarships to come, of farflung clubs of Infonauts sharing their finds, the promoter speaks of kids whose minds will "go where no mind has gone before."

If the strategy is to work, however, there must be a font of information large enough to be genuinely useful for just about any assignment, a means of searching that produces meaningful results and an easy way for a child to use it.

Finally, it must be affordable. Weinberger initially set $10 a month for unlimited usage as a figure he would consider reasonable.

That's a lot to live up to, and Homework Helper has a long way to go to meet the lofty goals set for it. The initial attempt is at once exciting and disappointing.

The electronic library, known in the computer industry as a database, contains some gems and will grow with time, but it is not yet comprehensive enough for a high school student to do serious research.

After a couple of attempts to use the program for social science projects, my 15-year-old sophomore reluctantly resorted to the hardbound materials in his school library.

Despite some extraordinary statistics, such as one that claims nearly 500,000 newspapers are contained in the on-line library, the real contents of Homework Helper are considerably more modest.

There is one national newspaper, USA Today, and one major metropolitan daily, the Los Angeles Times. The number of newspapers cited actually represents a count of the newspaper articles.

There are similar stretchers in the figures claiming 68,000 magazines and more than 175 books.

Most of the 100 or so books on the list are actually periodicals devoted to computers, making Homework Helper a good source for a paper on the latest industry hype, but hardly a treasure trove for someone in search of political commentary or literary criticism.

The stacks contain one encyclopedia, Compton's, and will soon acquire another.

That shortcoming is reparable simply by adding more materials, which undoubtedly will come if the project takes off.

Of greater concern is the "search engine," the computer software that attempts to match a user's request for information with the relevant materials in the database.

Homework Helper uses a technique called "natural language" searching, a tremendous advance for amateur researchers who haven't been trained in Boolean logic, a strict and often frustrating system.

Whereas Boolean searches identify exact sequences of letters to find relevant text, natural language searching looks up the words you choose in a thesaurus, adds the most likely synonyms and checks the database for frequent repetitions of those words, sorting the results in the order most likely to match the request.

"Natural language searching is something I've cared about for a long time, but I don't think it should be overhyped," says Matthew Koll, who heads Personal Library Software, a player in the search and retrieval systems industry.

I tried asking Homework Helper some pretty simple factual questions, such as "How did George Washington die?" and "When did George Washington die?"

The program was stumped.

The answers are almost certainly in the encyclopedia, if nowhere else in the billion-word library.

It did better on Weinberger's own personal favorite, "Why is the sky blue?" The program found Lord Kelvin's 19th century explanation of the refraction of light, as well as some poems about space.

As for Weinberger's dream of letting curious young minds roam the nether reaches of the universe of knowledge, few parents can afford to let their children wander aimlessly on-line.

To use Homework Helper, you must subscribe to Prodigy for $9.95 a month, and download special software that enables the program to run on your computer. You can then get up to two hours of time on Homework Helper for an additional $9.95 and pay Prodigy's $2.95 surcharge for each additional hour. Or you can use Homework Helper for a straight $6 an hour.

Essentially, to give his service national exposure and offer millions of children access to it, Weinberger made a pact with Prodigy that effectively leaves a meter running at the library door. It's a shame to shut out so many kids who might benefit from it.

Michael Putzel, a member of the Globe staff, can be reached by e-mail at putzel@globe.com or by paper mail c/o Plugged In, The Boston Globe, Boston, MA, 02107-2378.

> "As for Weinberger's dream of letting curious young minds roam the nether reaches of the universe of knowledge, few parents can afford to let their children wander aimlessly on-line."

calendar

MEETING: Boston Computer Society Emerging Technologies Group. Topic: "On the Wireless Frontier." First public Boston-area demo of new MARCO wireless communicator, based on Apple Newton, along with new wireless features for the ENVOY PDA running Magic Cap OS. Wed., Feb. 15, 7 p.m., Boston Computer Society, 101 First Ave., Waltham. For more information call 617-290-5700.

MEETING: Telecommunication Policy Roundtable/Northeast Topic: "How Communities Can Make the Information Highway Come to Town." Wed., Feb. 15, 7-9 p.m., Emerson College, 180 Tremont St. For more information, contact Phyllis Haynes, 617-421-0111

DEMO: See the first Magic Cap and Telescript-based products and services from Sony and AT&T, Wed., Feb. 15, 7 p.m., Ballroom C, Hynes Convention Center. Sony will give away two Magic Link communicators after the meeting. General Magic T-shirts will be given to the first 100 people at the door. Call Boston Computer Society, 617-290-5700 x3317.

MEETING: The Association for Computing Machinery. JoAnne Yates, MIT Sloan School of Management, will speak on: "From Tabulators to Early Computers in the US Life Insurance Industry: Influences, Continuities and Implications for Today." Thurs., Feb. 16, 7 p.m. Refreshments at 6:30. Newman Auditorium, BBN, Inc., 70 Fawcett St, Cambridge. Call 617-862-1181, free to the public.

SEMINAR: The Boston Computer Society's Small Office/Home Office Group will present Lyn Branscomb of Lyn Branscomb Marketing Communications, speaking on "Sales Letters that Sell." Tues., Feb. 14, 7-9 p.m., BCS Office, 101 First Ave., Waltham. Call 617-290-5700.

MEETING: Multimedia Monday Night, an informal discussion group sponsored by the Boston Computer Society's New Media Group. Mondays, 6:30 p.m., Cafe Liberty, 497 B Massachusetts Ave. Call Richard Bond 617-449-9415 for information.

mail bag

The American Academy of Arts and Sciences has officially opened a World Wide Web site at http://www.amacad.org. The academy is an honorary society, which recognizes achievement in the natural sciences, social sciences, arts, and humanities and conducts a varied program of projects and studies responsive to the needs and problems of society. It also publishes DAEDALUS, an interdisciplinary academic journal.

For more information, write to pbendell@amacad.org.

PHYLLIS BENDELL

THE VOXBOX

voxbox@globe.com

Do you have an answer for the following? Send it to us by e-mail to voxbox@globe.com and we'll run the best response in the Monday Voxbox column.

For many Internet users, access to the net is provided by their employer. Many companies have taken appropriate precautions to prevent viruses from infecting their computer systems. One type of protection architecture consists of having a "firewall," which effectively isolates all computers (except the firewall) from the net, and thus from being susceptible from viruses.

My question is, is it possible to access the WWW using a browser like Mosiac with this type of architecture? Does anyone know how would this work and is there software that could support this?

STEVE RAKITIN
steven.rakitin@cibadiag.com

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